

Chapter 1: The Ghost of Maple Grove

In the year 2138, the world that remained was a quiet ruin of overgrown lawns and sagging rooftops. Maple Grove had once been an ordinary suburban town. Now its streets cracked under weeds, its houses leaned like tired old men, and the only law left was the law of the clans. Survivors had rebuilt society the only way they still remembered—high-school tribes. Nerds hoarded what little knowledge survived. Band geeks turned broken instruments into signals and noise. Jocks claimed the open fields and the old football stadium, ruling by muscle and steel. Trust was rare. Everyone carried weapons forged in the style of ancient Rome: short swords, spears, heavy shields hammered from scavenged metal. Guns were a forgotten myth, at least as far as anyone still living could prove.

Alex Rivera was nineteen and belonged to none of them. He had grown up far from any town, on a hard scrap of country land where the only teacher was necessity. He knew how to track, how to listen to the wind, how to make a meal from almost nothing, and how to stay invisible when larger, louder people decided the world belonged to them. That country childhood had kept him alive after the Scourge. It had also left him odd in the eyes of the survivors—nerdy in the way he studied old diagrams and quiet patterns, yet athletic enough to move like a hunter when the moment demanded it. He carried a Roman gladius at his hip and a light shield on his back. Across his shoulders rode something of his own invention: a makeshift crossbow built from scavenged wood, steel springs, and tensioned cord. It launched kitchen knives with enough force to punch through scrap armor at close range. He never showed it unless he had no other choice.

On a gray afternoon he moved through an abandoned house the way he always did—slow, methodical, checking every shadow. He found a sealed jar of pickled vegetables that had somehow survived the decades and slipped it into his pack. Outside, shouting rose. He peered through a gap in the boards.

A group of Jocks in patched football pads and dented breastplates had cornered two Nerds against a chain-link fence. Their leader, Brad “Titan” Voss, stood half a head taller than the rest. He carried a heavy Roman-style spatha and a rectangular shield reinforced

with car-hood steel. One of the Nerds, a thin man with cracked glasses, raised empty hands.

“We were just looking for batteries,” the Nerd said. “We weren’t—”

Titan’s spatha came down in a brutal, unnecessary arc. The blade sheared through the man’s raised forearm, severing it cleanly at the elbow. The Nerd screamed as arterial blood sprayed across the cracked asphalt. Titan did not stop. He drove the point of the sword into the man’s gut, twisted, and ripped upward, opening him from navel to sternum. Intestines spilled in a wet coil. The Nerd collapsed, still twitching, trying to hold his own insides in with the stump of his arm.

The second Nerd tried to run. Titan’s men tripped him with a spear shaft. Titan stepped on the back of the man’s neck, pinning him face-down, then raised the heavy spatha high and brought it down again and again—hacking through spine, ribs, and finally the skull with wet, deliberate cracks until the body stopped moving and the head was little more than red pulp. Titan wiped the blade on the dead man’s shirt, breathing hard from the effort, and smiled.

“You read books,” he said to the corpses. “Books don’t feed us. Hands do. And now neither of you has either.”

Alex watched only long enough to be sure the path was clear, then left by the back window. He did not interfere. Interference got people killed, and he had learned long ago that the country taught a simple rule: survive first.

Chapter 2: The Girl with the Rash

That evening he sat alone on a rusted jungle gym in the overgrown park, eating the cold pickles and sketching in a small notebook—water sources, weak points in armor, the angles of Roman formations he had taught himself from a single surviving book. A soft cough broke the quiet.

Jordan Hale stood at the edge of the trees. Eighteen, pale under a hood, a light spear in one hand. A faint dark rash traced the side of her neck. She did not raise the weapon.

"You're the one they call the Ghost," she said. "No clan."

Alex closed the notebook. "And you're the one who's supposed to be gone by now."

Jordan almost smiled. She sat at a careful distance. "Not yet. The Scourge takes its time with some of us. It isn't contagious anymore—hasn't been for years. But it's still killing me. Faster every week."

Before Alex could answer, a smaller figure burst from the undergrowth. Sam Hale was fourteen, wild-eyed, filthy, clutching a sharpened length of rebar like a Roman pilum.

Sam snarled at Alex and planted both feet between him and Jordan, ready to kill.

"Sam. Stop," Jordan said quietly.

Sam did not lower the weapon, but the murder in those eyes softened only for Jordan. Protective. Homicidal to everything else.

"Younger sibling?" Alex asked.

"The only family left," Jordan answered. "Don't make a sudden move. Sam doesn't do sudden moves well."

Alex stayed still. After a long moment Sam retreated a few steps but never fully turned away.

Chapter 3: Distance and Knives

In the days that followed they met at the same park at dusk. Always at a distance. Sam watched from the trees like a feral guard. Alex left clean water and dried meat. Jordan left scavenged antibiotics that no longer worked and a small carved wooden bird. They talked in low voices about the early years of the Scourge—how three-quarters of the world had vanished in eighteen months—and about the strange high-school order the survivors had rebuilt.

Alex admitted he had never fit. Too quiet for the Jocks. Too physical for the Nerds. The

country had taught him self-reliance instead of belonging. He showed her the crossbow once, demonstrating how a kitchen knife could fly true when the tension was right.

Jordan watched without flinching, even as the black veins under her skin spread farther each evening.

One night her cough was worse. The rash had darkened. She looked at him without self-pity.

“No cure,” she said. “Never was. I just slow it down as long as I can. Don’t get close enough to matter.”

Alex did not move closer. But he stayed longer.

Chapter 4: Blood on the Grass

In the old football stadium that same night, Titan addressed a circle of warriors under torchlight, still flecked with dried blood from the afternoon’s work.

“The Ghost has been seen with the infected girl,” Titan said. “And that little animal she calls a brother. We don’t let the Scourge walk free. We end it. Clean.”

Spears thumped against shields in agreement.

Alex arrived at the park to find Jordan waiting, urgency in her face.

“They’re coming for us,” she said. “Titan’s people. Sam heard them.”

Torches appeared at the tree line with Titan leading the way.

Sam exploded from cover first—screaming, the rebar spear flying. A Jock went down with a punctured thigh, blood pumping between his fingers. Sam was pure violence, small and fast, cutting another across the face so deep the man’s cheek flapped open and his eye filled with blood. Titan stepped forward and, with a single brutal swing of the heavy spatha, drove the blade through Sam’s chest, the point bursting out between the shoulder blades in a spray of dark arterial blood. Titan twisted the sword, grinding bone, then yanked it free. Sam’s eyes found Jordan one last time—fierce, protective—then emptied. The body dropped, twitching once before going still.

Jordan’s scream tore the night. She lunged. Alex intercepted her, hauling her back as spears leveled toward them.

“The animal’s done,” Titan said, blood still dripping from his blade. “The girl next. Or the Ghost can watch.”

Alex’s gladius was already in his hand. He did not speak. He moved.

What followed was not a brawl. It was the economy of someone who had learned to survive in open country. Alex used the trees, the broken playground equipment, the darkness. He shielded Jordan with his body and forced Titan’s men into single file between slides and swings. One fell to a precise thrust under the arm that punched out the other side in a gout of blood. Another took a shield-bash that shattered his nose and teeth before the gladius opened his throat. When the circle closed, Alex unslung the crossbow.

A kitchen knife hissed through the air and buried itself deep in a Jock’s eye socket, the force dropping him instantly. Another knife took a second man in the throat; he clawed at the steel, choking on his own blood as he collapsed. Titan himself was stronger, heavier—but slower. Alex bled him methodically: a slash across the thigh that severed the artery, a cut to the sword arm that left fingers dangling by tendons. Titan roared and charged, swinging wildly. Alex sidestepped and drove the gladius up under the breastplate, the blade punching through lung and heart. Titan staggered, blood pouring from his mouth, stared at the steel in his gut, then collapsed face-first into the dirt, still twitching as he drowned in his own blood.

Silence. The remaining Jocks scattered into the dark, leaving their dead behind.

Alex stood over Titan’s body, breathing hard, the crossbow still cocked in one hand.

Jordan was on her knees beside Sam, rocking the small corpse, her hands slick with her sibling’s blood. The rash on her neck looked darker under the abandoned torchlight.

Chapter 5: What Remains

At dawn they buried Sam in the soft earth beneath the jungle gym. No words. Jordan placed the wooden bird on the grave.

“Sam only ever loved one person,” she said. “Now that person is running out of time...”

Alex finally sat close enough that their shoulders almost touched.

“Then we use the time,” he answered.

Jordan looked at him. The virus was still there, killing her quickly. The clans still existed. Trust was still rare. But for the first time since the world ended, neither of them was completely alone.

They stood. Alex offered his free hand—not to hold, but to steady. Jordan took it for three heartbeats, then let go. They walked out of the park together, two figures against the ruined suburban skyline, gladius and spear ready, the makeshift crossbow riding across Alex’s shoulders.

The sun rose over a world that still believed only the strong and the grouped survived. But the country had taught Alex something different. And Jordan, for as long as the Scourge allowed, had chosen to walk beside him anyway.